Kabul to 'help the oppressed East Bengalis materially by reviving their vocal interest in the Pakhtoon movement'.[51] Karachi, however, was the trade lifeline for a landlocked Afghanistan, and instability within Pakistan could destabilise Afghanistan. Such concerns among the Afghan leadership persisted even after Bangladesh's creation, as Bhutto cracked down on Baloch and Pashtun separatists. By 1974, Kabul and New Delhi became increasingly alarmed by Bhutto's propaganda on India and Afghanistan's continuous collusion in fomenting separatism in Pakistan.[52]

Fearful of losing power domestically and further territorial disintegration, Bhutto dismissed the NAP government in February 1973 and imposed martial law. Whereas disturbances in the NWFP were common occurrences since 1947, imposition of martial law exploded the dormant Balochistan movement into a full-fledged insurgency by early 1974. The Balochistan People's Liberation Front (BPLF), which emerged as the key resistance group led by Mir Hazar Ramkhani, launched a series of attacks on Pakistani military installations. In 1975, the BPLF shifted its base from Balochistan to Afghanistan.[53] Despite underlying tensions between Pashtun and Baloch nationalisms (wherein Baluchistan was viewed as 'southern Pashtunistan'), Kabul threw its weight behind the separatists. Recruiting fighters from the Baloch and Pashtun refugee camps that were setup all across the border areas, it launched attacks from its new headquarters in Kandahar, and the fort of Kalat-i-Ghilzai, just outside Kandahar. Three forward operating bases were also setup along the border near Chaman, Dohmandi, and Gulistan areas.[54] As the number of refugees pouring into Afghanistan rose, anti-Pakistan sentiment in Kabul rose proportionately, and so did international condemnation of Islamabad's crackdown.[55] In April 1975, Pakistan received a 'rude surprise', by the then UN Secretary-General Kurt Waldheim's 'positive response' to Kabul's official complaint of a bulging refugee crises on it soil and Pakistan's 'acts of suppression in Baluchistan'.[56]

Secondly, departing from their declared objective of non-alignment, both India and Afghanistan undertook a strong tilt towards the Soviet Union in the early 1970s. For Kabul especially, by the mid-1970s, India became the second 'most important' country to cultivate good relations with, after the Soviet Union, in order to exert pressure on Pakistan over Pashtunistan.[57] Just as the importance